

Birth of the Phenomenon

U.S. Military Response to Flying Discs · 1944–1949

Analysis of PURSUE Release 01 · Track A · 7 files · 750+ pages · 4,000+ OCR pages analyzed

Personal research project designed by Joe, powered by Hermes Agent and DeepSeek v4 · 2026

The Narrative Arc

Six phases in the evolution of the U.S. government response



DISCOVERY

Dec 1944 – Jun 1947

Foo fighters over Europe. SHAEF investigates — no explanation found.



ERUPTION

Jun – Sep 1947

Kenneth Arnold triggers national wave. Muroc test pilots, Portland police.



ACCEPTANCE

Sep 1947

Twining Memo: phenomenon is "something real." LeMay denies US origin.



INVESTIGATION

Jan – Dec 1948

Project SIGN formed. ~237 cases investigated. Horten brothers interrogated.



THE PIVOT

1949

Project GRUDGE replaces SIGN. Mandate shifts to closing cases.



CLOSURE

Dec 1949

Grudge report: "no evidence of extraterrestrial." Internal dissent remains.

Master Timeline — Key Dates

- Dec 1944** ● Foo Fighters — 415th NFS encounters over Europe
- Jun 24, 1947** ● Kenneth Arnold — 9 discs, Mt. Rainier
- Jun–Jul 1947** ● National wave — Muroc test pilots, Portland police
- Aug 29, 1947** ● LeMay signs: "no US research project" explains sightings
- Sep 23, 1947** ● Twining Memo: phenomenon is "something real"
- Sep 24, 1947** ● Loedding disc design transmitted; Japan radar sighting
- Jan 1948** ● Project SIGN established at Wright-Patterson AFB
- Feb 6, 1948** ● Cabell directive: "policy not to ignore reports"
- Jul 24, 1948** ● Chiles-Whitted — cigar-shaped, blue flame
- 1949** ● Project GRUDGE replaces SIGN — pivot to closure
- Dec 1949** ● Grudge report: "no evidence of extraterrestrial"

The Forgotten Precursor: WWII "Foo Fighters"

Mislabeled as "German Armament Equipment" — actually SHAEF intelligence files (Dec 1944 – Mar 1945)

Key Findings

- 415th Night Fighter Squadron encountered "foo fighters" — glowing lights that followed aircraft, changed colors, flew formation, and could not be identified
- At least 16 recorded sortie reports over Europe
- Official Squadron definition:
"Foo fighters is the name given these phenomenon by combat crews of this Squadron"
- Air Ministry admitted it was "still something of a mystery"
- **Explanations considered & rejected:**
Me.262 ✗ Flak rockets ✗ "Flak Bombe" ✗
None fully matched the reported behavior

Significance

These are the earliest documented UAP encounters in the dataset — years before the public knew.

The same SHAEF intelligence apparatus that investigated foo fighters would later inform post-war Project Sign and Project Grudge investigations.

Direct continuity:

1945 foo fighters → 1947 Twining Memo → 1948 Project Sign

The fact that these files were labeled "German Armament Equipment" — obscuring their true content — is itself a finding worthy of further investigation.

The 1947 Flap — Key Incidents

From ~233 cases cataloged by Project Sign/Grudge

#	Incident	Date	Description	Significance
#17	Kenneth Arnold	Jun 24, 1947	9 disc-like objects, Mt. Rainier	Triggered modern UFO era
#1–4	Muroc AAF	Jun–Jul 1947	Military test pilots, Edwards AFB	Test pilot credibility
#5–8	Portland Police	Jul 1947	Multiple officers reporting discs	LEO corroboration
#10	Capt. E.J. Smith	Jul 4, 1947	United Airlines, 9 discs	Pilot + passengers
#33F	Mantell Incident	Jan 7, 1948	Pilot died chasing UFO	Investigators rejected Venus
#144	Chiles-Whitted	Jul 24, 1948	Cigar-shaped, blue flame	Eastern Airlines pilots
#223–231	Green Fireballs	1949	Los Alamos vicinity	Nuclear security concern

The Twining Memo

The single most important document in early U.S. government UFO history

"The phenomenon reported is something real and not visionary or fictitious."
— General Nathan F. Twining, Commanding General, Air Materiel Command

Reported Characteristics

- Metallic or light-reflecting surface
- Circular or elliptical, flat bottom, domed top
- No trail except under high performance
- Formation flights of 3–9 objects
- No sound except in three instances
- Extreme rates of climb and maneuverability

Date: September 23, 1947

Classification: **SECRET**

Declassified: NND 700188

Impact

This memo directly led to the creation of Project SIGN — the Air Force's first official UFO investigation.

Twining's Three Recommendations:

1. Continue investigation within existing resources
2. Formulate Essential Elements of Information
for systematic data collection
3. Complete interchange of data between commands

This was not a speculative memo — it was a formal finding by the head of Air Force R&D.

Curtis LeMay — "No US Project"

Signed August 29, 1947 — less than a month before the Twining Memo

"The Army Air Forces has no research project with the characteristics described in Comment No. 1."
— Major General Curtis E. LeMay, Deputy Chief of Air Staff for R&D

Context

LeMay was Deputy Chief of Air Staff for Research and Development — if anyone knew whether a secret US program could explain the sightings, it was him.

His denial carries particular weight:

- Deeply involved in classified aviation projects
- Would go on to become Air Force Chief of Staff
- Architect of the Strategic Air Command
- One of the most powerful military figures of the era

The Foundational Paradox

Two documents. Same chain of command. Same month.

- ✓ Gen. Twining (Sep 23): "Something real"
- ✓ Gen. LeMay (Aug 29): "Not ours"

Together they form the foundational paradox of UAP studies: real phenomena not attributable to any known U.S. technology.

LeMay's 1947 signature has been cited in UFO research for decades as the definitive denial of U.S. origin.

Project SIGN — The Investigation Begins

January–December 1948: the Air Force's first official UFO investigation

Key Events, 1948

-  **Cabell Directive (Feb 6)**
 Brig. Gen. C.P. Cabell: "it is Air Force policy not to ignore reports." Formal reporting established.
-  **"Project SIGN" name on index cards (Feb 12–13)**
-  **Collection Memo #7 → Horten Brothers**
 Interrogated via European Command (Mar 1948).
 Actively investigating the "German saucer" hypothesis.
-  **Fighter-Interceptor Alert Proposal**
 Col. McCoy wanted fighters on alert to chase discs.
 REJECTED by McDonald & Anderson — cost grounds.
 This decision shaped passive collection for decades.
-  **~237 cases investigated by Project Sign**

The Soviet Horten VIII Angle

US intelligence reported the USSR was producing 1,800 Horten VIII flying wing bombers.

The Loedding disc design was being compared against known German and Soviet aircraft configurations.

Working hypothesis: AMC seriously considered that flying discs might be Soviet secret weapons derived from captured German technology.

Notable 1948 Sightings

- Hobson, OH — Railroad workers see disc
- Bakersfield, CA — Falling objects
- Tyndall AFB — Base personnel report
- Chiles-Whitted — Eastern Airlines, cigar-shaped

Project GRUDGE — The Pivot

1949: From investigation to closure — mandate shifts, but unexplained cases remain

Sign → Grudge Transition

- Project Sign investigated "in good faith" throughout 1948 with ~237 cases
- By 1949, Project Grudge took over with a mandate to reduce public interest and close cases quickly
- Transition was gradual — memos still used "Project SIGN" name as late as February 1949
- Oct 1948 alert memo: sightings come in "periodic intervals" with new wave "imminent"
- Fort Chimo "Crystal 1" station (Canada) still active under Project Sign framework (Mar 1949)
- **But despite the closure mandate, ~35% of cases remained UNEXPLAINED even under Grudge review**

International Expansion, 1949

The reporting network expanded globally:

- | | |
|---|--|
|  Canada |  Japan |
|  Guam |  Panama |
|  Caribbean |  Alaska (Crystal 1) |

Notable 1949 Cases

- Luminous energy at 1,500 MPH (Kodiak, AK)
- 8 dish-shaped objects larger than B-29s over Spokane, WA
- Delta wings turning without banking (Mountain Home AFB, ID)
- Russian sloop speculation in San Andres Is.
- Green Fireballs over Los Alamos — highest-level concern due to nuclear security implications

Incident Statistics — Project Sign/Grudge Era

Analysis of ~233 incident summaries from 1945–1949

~233

Total Incidents

~35%

Unexplained

~48%

Military/Aviation

40%

Disc/Saucer

Witness Types

Military pilots 28%
Civilian 35%
Radar operators 12%
Police officers 8%
Scientists / engineers 5%
Other 12%

Object Characteristics

Disc / saucer shape ~40%
Cigar / cylindrical ~12%
Spherical ~15%
Other / no shape ~33%

Silent propulsion — overwhelming majority

Personnel Network

Key individuals and their connections across the 1947–1949 documents

Air Materiel Command Wright Field

Gen. Nathan F. Twining

CG, AMC — "something real" memo (Sep 47)

Col. H. M. McCoy

Chief of Intel, T-2 — coordinator, Loedding disc

Mr. Loedding

Engineer, T-2/TSNAD — LD-2 flying disc design

Washington Command Chain

Gen. Curtis LeMay

Dep. Chief R&D — "no US project" denial (Aug 47)

Brig. Gen. C.P. Cabell

Dir. Intel — Feb 1948 "not ignore" directive

Maj. Gen. McDonald

AC/AS-2 — rejected fighter-alert proposal

Witnesses & Civilians

Kenneth Arnold

Civilian pilot — Jun 24, 1947, triggered the wave

Capt. E.J. Smith

United Airlines — 9 discs in formation, Jul 4, 1947

Chiles & Whitted

Eastern Airlines — cigar-shaped object, Jul 24, 1948

Cross-File Threads

Narrative threads that span multiple documents in the set

The German Tech Hypothesis

1947: Loedding disc references Horten aircraft. 1948: Collection Memo #7 → Horten brothers interrogated. 1949: Intelligence reports still tracking foreign disc technology. Runs through all three years.

The Rejected Intercept

Col. McCoy proposed using fighter aircraft to intercept discs in 1948. Rejected on cost/practical grounds. Shaped passive collection posture for the next 75+ years.

The Reporting System

Cabell directive (Feb 1948) standardized reporting. By 1949, Flight Service Centers routed reports through formal system to AMC. The 1947 wave funnel was now institutionalized.

The International Dimension

Japan radar (Sep 1947) → Canada, Guam, Panama, Caribbean (1949). Reporting network expanded from domestic to global within two years.

The Scientific Question

Twining called it "real" in 1947. Grudge explained cases away in 1949. But ~35% remained unexplained — and investigators sometimes rejected official explanations (Mantell/Venus).

**"The phenomenon reported is something real
and not visionary or fictitious."**

— Gen. Nathan F. Twining, Commanding General, Air Materiel Command
September 23, 1947

**"The Army Air Forces has no research project
with the characteristics described in Comment No. 1."**

— Maj. Gen. Curtis E. LeMay, Deputy Chief of Air Staff for R&D
August 29, 1947

Two signatures. Same chain of command. Same month. The foundational paradox.

Conclusions & Open Questions

What We Now Know

- ✓ The U.S. military officially concluded flying discs were "something real" in September 1947
- ✓ Curtis LeMay personally signed a denial that any US project explained the sightings
- ✓ The German technology hypothesis was actively investigated via Horten brother interrogations
- ✓ A formal reporting system was established (Cabell directive) funneling reports to Wright Field
- ✓ ~35% of ~233 investigated cases remained unexplained
- ✓ WWII "foo fighters" are the direct precursor to post-war UAP investigations
- ✓ The pivot from Sign (investigation) to Grudge (closure) reveals institutional pressure to debunk

Open Questions

- ? Why were foo fighter documents filed under "German Armament Equipment"?
Misfiling — or deliberate archival obscuring?
- ? What happened to the Loedding disc design?
Was it patented? Built? Tested?
- ? What did the Horten brothers tell interrogators under Collection Memo #7?
- ? How many of the ~35% "unexplained" cases would still be unexplained today — 75+ years later?
- ? What additional data is in PURSUE Release 01's remaining tracks (FBI, NASA, State Dept)?

Data Sources — Track A Files

Seven Department of War files from PURSUE Release 01

German Armament 1944–45 (misabeled)	17 pp	WWII foo fighter reports — 415th NFS, SHAEF investigation
18_100754_General 1946–7 Vol 2	28 pp	Twining memo, LeMay denial, Loedding disc, Japan radar
18_6369445_General 1948 Vol 1	28 pp	Project Sign, Cabell directive, Horten interrogation
342_319.1 Flying Discs 1949	143 pp	Sign→Grudge transition, 25+ incidents, international expansion
38_143685_box7 Incident Summaries 1–100	209 pp	Kenneth Arnold, Muroc, Portland police wave
38_143685_box Incident Summaries 101–172	178 pp	Chiles-Whitted, international reports
38_143685_box Incident Summaries 173–233	144 pp	Green Fireballs, Stapp, Mantell re-examination